ridden second term in office, it became a cross that was too heavy for the government, party and eventually, the country, to bear. When the nation was looking for a strong, decisive leader who could take charge, Dr Singh went into silent mode. The joke that the only time he opened his mouth was when he had a dentist's appointment may have been cruel, but it reflected the exasperation of even his admirers who once saw him as a middle-class hero who had guided the economy through a critical period in the 1990s. Lamentably, the 'retirement' press conference was actually the first of its kind that he held since the onset of UPA-II.

Dr Singh's decision to quit politics was not unexpected. But in the build-up to the sixteenth general elections, it only highlighted the Congress's dilemma—a hapless prime minister ready to take sanyas and an untested young heir who appeared reluctant to take charge. The all-powerful *gaddi* of Delhi looked vacant. One man from Gujarat smelt his big chance.